Guidelines for Discussion Section Debates
NEU/PSYC C61: Brain, Mind, and Behavior – Fall 2026

There will be two debates during discussion section. Debate #1 will be in Week 7, and Debate #2 will be during Week 13. The topics will be announced in class and will subsequently be posted on bCourses and the course website.

For each debate, half the class will participate in the debate (arguing either the affirmative or negative position). The other half of the class will not be verbally debating but will instead be actively engaged as an audience. If you are in the audience, you will submit a brief write-up, detailed below. If you are actively debating for Debate #1, you will be in the audience for Debate #2, and vice versa. We expect that the debate groups will meet outside of class time to prepare for the debate.

DEBATE STRUCTURE:

1. Opening Arguments/Statements
   - Affirmative 6 minutes
   - Negative 6 minutes

2. Team huddle to prepare rebuttal 2 minutes

3. Rebuttal Round
   - Negative responds to affirmative's opening arguments 4 minutes
   - Affirmative responds to negative's opening arguments 4 minutes

4. Team huddle to prepare closing statements 2 minutes

5. Closing Arguments/Statements
   - Affirmative 3 minutes
   - Negative 3 minutes

6. Questions from Audience and further discussion 5-7 minutes

The opening arguments should be clear statements with supporting evidence. If possible, make connections between your arguments and the themes of our class, and you can use what you've learned in readings and lectures.

The rebuttal round will be responses to arguments presented during the opening round. New material should not be introduced in the rebuttal round, except insofar as it is relevant in response to the points being addressed.

The closing statements should be clear, strong, supported by evidence, and aimed at convincing your audience.

EVERYONE in each group is expected to say something during the debate.

WRITTEN ASSIGNMENTS:

For students NOT assigned to a debate team (audience members):

Students who are not assigned to the teams for the debate topic of the week should come to section prepared to give their full attention to the debate and contribute to the discussion. You are the engaged audience. "Full attention" means full attention, e.g., no use of electronic devices in the audience during the debate.

To assist with preparation, write a short statement (approximately half a page) stating your opinion on the debate topic, supported by at least one reference to an article, book, or website, NOT including the articles assigned to the class for reading.

Your write-up must be hand-written on a sheet of paper. Please take a photo and submit it via bCourses, with your name and student ID on it. You may only submit a typed response if you have a documented DSP accommodation for handwritten assignments.

For students who ARE assigned to one of the debate teams:

Each person on a debate team should compose a half page summary of a resource (article, book, website) that you personally used in preparing for the debate, together with a citation to the source (NOT including the articles assigned to the class for reading). If the source is a website, please also comment on the likely reliability of the information on the website.

Your write-up must be hand-written on a sheet of paper. Please take a photo and submit it via bCourses, with your name and student ID on it. You may only submit a typed response if you have a documented DSP accommodation for handwritten assignments.

ALL WRITE-UPS ARE DUE VIA BCOURSES AT 11:59PM, SUNDAY OCTOBER 4TH!

GRADING RUBRIC:

Debate Team Rubric (7 points)

- Argument Quality & Evidence (2 pts): Presented clear, well-supported arguments during opening/closing; connected points to course readings, lectures, or themes where relevant.
- Rebuttal & Responsiveness (1.5 pts): Directly addressed the opposing team's arguments; stayed within rebuttal norms (no unrelated new material introduced).
- Team Participation (1.5 pts): Every team member spoke and contributed meaningfully; team appeared prepared and worked cohesively.
- Individual Write-Up (2 pts): Half-page, hand-written summary of a resource used in preparation, with a citation; submitted correctly with name and student ID.

Audience Member Rubric (7 points)

- Attendance & Attention (2 pts): Present for the full debate; fully attentive throughout (no electronic device use during the debate).
- Participation in Discussion (2 pts): 70% or more of the audience must verbally participate in the discussion by asking a question or making a comment, in order for everyone to get the points.
- Written Opinion Statement (3 pts): Half-page, hand-written statement clearly stating an opinion on the debate topic, supported by at least one reference (article, book, or website); submitted correctly with name and student ID.